Hiraeth, Mother of Monsters

Hiraeth is my take on a science-fantasy setting that I can design adventures for, set campaigns in, and write fiction about. For those who are unfamiliar with science-fantasy as a genre, imagine knights wearing armor and fighting with swords in the wreckage of a spaceship. It is a genre where advanced technology like lasers and flying machines exist alongside magic, ancient prophecies, noble warriors, and outlandish creatures. It describes worlds where swashbuckling pirates may communicate with short-range radios, and artists perfect alchemical blends to capture still-life images of their subjects on panes of glass. The possibilities are endless when combining the unchecked imagination of fantasy with the careful inspection of science-fiction.

In designing Hiraeth, I am drawing inspiration from all kinds of sources, such as books like Walter M. Miller's *A Canticle for Leibowitz*, Frank Herbert's *Dune*, and Edgar Rice Burrough's *Barsoom* series, as well as the cultural giants of fiction to whom all writers owe some piece of their inspiration, like *Star Wars*, and *The Lord of the Rings*. Truth be told, however, since I am a musician at heart, I actually draw the greatest share of my inspiration from the music and lyrics that I love.

Hiraeth is a barren rock, once named "The Mother of Monsters". In a time before time, it was little more than a useful outpost between better, brighter stars; a place nobody comes to with the intention of staying. The day the Leywork finally broke, I don't imagine there was a more unfortunate place to find yourself trapped. When people were forced to stay, the mysteries of Hiraeth began to reveal themselves. Unanswered riddles from before the Leywork, before mankind. Reality on Hiraeth is unpredictable, constantly shifting. It is a world where nothing stays quite the way you left it. No one can build a true image of the world's history, and it may not matter—because only one thing is certain: Hiraeth is not our home.

The Pitch

- The Time Before Time: Countless ages ago, species from all over the universe rode along a limitless web of energy called the Leywork. Mankind was most efficient in harnessing the power of the Leywork, and used it to build great inter-solar empires. The things people achieved with the Leywork far exceeded the dreams of scientists of our own time, and one day, without warning or explanation, the Leywork vanished. Empires of a thousand thousand planets, now a thousand thousand orphans, adrift, alone.
- Hiraeth is inhospitable. Except for a few temperate places, Hiraeth is a sun-blasted desert bounded by nauseatingly high plateaus and topped with a frigid polar icecap. The crucible of Hiraeth's harsh environments have forged dangerous monsters. Generations of people have fought and died to carve out a sliver of the world that is safe to live in, but the wilderness remains solely the possession of fierce animals, dangerous plants, and demons, always reaching to reclaim protected lands.
- The world is older than reckoning. Hiraeth is covered in tombs, crumbling strongholds, forgotten temples, and even older, deeper ruins, left behind by a lost civilization whose disappearance predates the Leywork—*The Eld*. Frighteningly little is known about the Eld and the events that precipitated their demise, but some hopeful scientists speculate that their ruins hold the secret to restoring the Leywork.
- Magic is the expression of willpower. Some people have the power to make things happen simply by imagining them. Some regard those with this power as being favored by the gods, while others fear and despise these magicians. While everyone has some semblance of magical power flowing through them, only a few can actually turn this force outwards on the world around them.
- Technology is uncommon, but powerful. By re-engineering and reinventing broken scraps of technology from the days of the Leywork, people have created incredible things; trains, flying machines, radios, photography, and more. Advanced technology is hoarded by wealthy aristocrats, however. You may find in some places that people can communicate with distant cities through ancient networks of underground cables, while in other places, people have little more than the soil they've fortified and the food it bears them.

The world of our ancestors is dead and gone. What once was has been lost to an endlessly rolling tide of smoke. The tale of the world we lost and how we lost it is confined only to legend now. Nevertheless, a few truths are known for sure:

Each player, starting with the player to the right of the GM, makes a single-sentence statement about the old world, or how the old world was lost. It may be as vague or as specific as the player wishes, but it must be brief. This statement is now a necessarily true statement on this subject matter. The GM provides the closing statement. Give players 5 mins. to prepare their statement of truth.

Through happenstance, or sheer will to survive, our ancestors found this place – *the valley*. Ever since, our people have lived here, and it has become another home to us. What is the name of the valley?

Each player (but not the GM) is given 5 minutes to think of a suitable name and write it down on a notecard. When finished, the notecards are placed in a hat (or something), shaken, and then one is drawn at random. Leave that card face down. Next, draw the remaining cards one by one and read them out. These are names that various people have given to the valley throughout history, but the one, most persistent name is contained on the card that remains face down. Read that card. This is regarded as the official name of the valley.

Threats

Hiraeth is full of monsters and threats of all kinds. While the wilderness is a great peril of its own, some people find themselves in just as much danger in settled lands.

Ghosts

When a person dies, their misdeeds and corruption cannot travel to the afterlife. Instead, they remain and fester, forming a malevolent ghost that inspires fear and carries illness. Though untouchable and often invisible, ghosts are perceived through a sense of looming evil, typically expressed through an uneasy feeling or inexplicable terror. While they can attack people and

make them sick, ghosts cannot be defeated through normal means. Usually, one must undergo a quest to undo the deceased's corruption; a promise that was broken must be kept, a wound that was inflicted must be healed.

The Inside-Out People

In times of great hunger and desperation, people are sometimes forced to debase themselves with heinous acts to survive. To endure the trauma and shame of such acts, one must divorce their consciousness from the self that makes them human. When the bad times end, the mind is sometimes unable to return, and these poor souls become *Inside-Out People* – selfish, vicious, hungry. Sometimes they travel in bands, searching for vulnerable people to snatch, defile, and devour. Worse still, through the torturous fracturing of the mind, they create more Inside-Out People.

He-Eats-Us

The Sirayem clans attest to the existence of a huge and powerful ogre, capable of seizing a human being in one hand and dashing his victim's head against a stone. He prefers to eat viscera, leaving the meat and bones for other creatures to devour. He uses long black claws to pluck the organs from his victims, and his yellow teeth fence a killing breath of black offal. Despite his immense size, he is fast and can easily hide in narrow ice canyons.

Night Stalkers

These horrifying demons reside in caves under the earth during the day. They detest sunlight, and have been known even to avoid nights when the moon is full and bright. Though they lack eyes, they easily navigate the darkness through low hooting, being easily mistaken for an owl. They have sickly white skin with bristling hair along their spines, but otherwise look almost like a person. They have long dark claws on their fingers and toes, and their limbs have too many joints. They have been known to paralyze their victims, dragging them to their honeycombed lairs deep beneath the surface.